

PAPERED OVER Women denied scheme benefits, Malda, Aug. 24 and (inset) suicide victim Anita Khatun

Takeaways

- **32-yr-old Malda woman's suicide sharpens debate over Annapurna's delayed payments**
- **Govt says list of beneficiaries being cleansed of ineligible names, others being verified**
- **Rs 3,000 p.m. was promised. but protesting women across state cite messy exclusions**

He claims men and even Bangladeshi nationals received benefits under the previous system."You would not want government money to be squandered like this," he said. That much was kosher. But the argument also collided with the lived experience of eligible women who had pinned their hopes on the money, and budgeted for it.

By August 21, protests spread across Bengal: Murshidabad, Cooch Behar, North and South 24 Parganas, Howrah, Hooghly, Sagardighi, Jangirpur, Dhulian. In Birati, women blocked rail tracks, disrupting Sealdah-bound services. Protesters confronted minister Agnimitra Paul in Midnapore. Some said better-off people had found their way into the list while poor women were out. The BJP ascribes the protests to the Opposition; the TMC accused it of making promises before the election and introducing conditions afterwards.

While insisting that every eligible woman would eventually be covered, Adhikari has increasingly chosen confrontation over retreat. "They can make reels for shock value and stage media trials by bringing out 20 people onto the streets," he said in Bhowanipore. "I won't bow my head." On September 16, Adhikari claimed that 14.8 million beneficiaries received money under the scheme in August and that a total of 15.8 million would receive the money in September. Meanwhile, September 17, Prime Minister Narendra Modi's birthday, was observed as 'Annapurna Diwas'. In an event in Kolkata, 100,000 beneficiaries participated. Contestation was countered by celebration. ■

▶ GUJARAT

The 'Ghost Demolition' Stalks Surat

Without warning or notice, 117 homes get flattened. A municipal and police posse was there—and not there

By **Jumana Shah**

It was like an army had massed at dawn for a surprise attack. On the morning of May 30, bulldozers arrived out of the blue at Nasirnagar, a slum settlement near Ved Darwaja in Surat's Katargam area. Without much ado, they began doing what bulldozers do: flattening homes. The residents, uncomprehending as their lives turned to debris, spoke through the shock. They had not been given any notice or hearing, they said. Impassive officials of the Surat Municipal Corporation (SMC), duly accompanied by a posse of policemen for protection, went ahead regardless. Over three days, the JCBs took down 117 dwellings.

That hard, empirical fact did nothing to dispel the sense of a ghostly storm come out of nowhere. When residents approached the SMC later to understand why the demolition was done without notice or eviction order, no government agency took responsi-

Takeaways

- **High court reconstructs mystery demolition of May 30 at Surat's Nasirnagar shanty**
- **JCBs take down homes, with officials overseeing job, but inquiries reveal no order**
- **Private interests said to be at play. But how could they get civic, police officials for job?**